

Conversion

doc-conversion

Soteriology · Conversion · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Conversion is the conscious human response to the gospel (repentance and faith) by which the regenerated sinner turns from sin to Christ; both gift of God and act of the believer.

In plain language

The proposition says conversion is the conscious human response to the gospel, a turning from sin to Christ in repentance and faith, and that it is at once a gift of God and an act of the believer. The central Greek word is the verb 'to turn' (epistrepho), which occurs thirty-six times, and in all four anchor verses the believers are the subject of an active form of it. In 1 Thessalonians 1:9 Paul says the readers turned (epestrepsate) to God from idols (eidolon) to serve the living and true God, with two small words marking direction, toward God and away from the idols. In Acts 3:19 Peter gives two commands together, 'repent and turn' (metanoesate kai epistrepsate), tied to the blotting out of sins (hamartia), and Jesus opens his preaching the same way in Mark 1:15, 'repent and believe' (metanoete kai pisteuete). In Acts 26:18 the risen Christ describes turning (epistrepesai) people from darkness to light so they receive forgiveness (aphesis) by faith (pistis), and in Acts 11:21 a great number, having believed (pisteusas), turned (epistrepseu) to the Lord, right after Luke says the hand of the Lord was with them. Repentance and faith are the two named facets of this one turning, stated plainly in Acts 20:21 as 'repentance toward God and faith toward the Lord' (metanoia and pistis). Behind all this stands the Hebrew word 'to turn or return' (shuv), which appears more than a thousand times across the whole Old Testament and carries the call to return to God in Joel 2:12, Zechariah 1:3, and Isaiah 44:22, so the motif runs through the entire canon rather than one writer. The genuine open question the words leave is how the human turning relates to God's work. The text itself uses the same roots both ways. In Lamentations 5:21 one line reads 'turn us' (hashivenu, the Hebrew causative form, the hiphil), with God as the one who turns, and then 'and we shall return' (venashuv, the simple active form, the qal), with the people turning. In Acts 11:18 God is said to grant the repentance (metanoia), and in 1 Peter 2:25 the turning verb is passive, 'you were turned' (epestraphete), while everywhere else it is active and the person turns. Because the canon states both the divine working and the human act with the same vocabulary and never ranks one over the other in the grammar, readers can stress either side and still affirm the proposition, which is why both gift and act stand together.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H7725	שוב	shuv	to return	1,056
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	175
G0859	ἄφεσις	aphesis	forgiveness	17
G1398	δουλεύω	douleuo	be a slave	27

G1497	εἶδωλον	eidolon	idol	11
G1813	ἐξαλείφω	exaleipho	to blot out	6
G1994	ἐπιστρέφω	epistrepheo	to turn	36
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2819	κλήρος	klēros	lot	
G3340	μετανοέω	metanoëo	to repent	36
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	243

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The conversion vocabulary is dense, stable, and spans the whole canon. In the Greek the verb 'to turn' (epistrepheo, G1994) occurs 36 times and in its religious use is consistently a turning to God away from sin or idols, and across the anchor verses the believers are the grammatical subject of an active verb of turning: in 1 Thessalonians 1:9 'you turned' (epistrepsate, parsed as a completed past action in the active voice, 2nd person plural, telling what the readers did) toward God (pros ton theon) away from idols (apo ton eidolon); in Acts 3:19 'turn' (epistrepsate, a completed past action used as a command, 2nd person plural) paired with 'repent' (metanoëte); in Acts 26:18 'to turn' (epistrepesai, a completed past action infinitive expressing purpose) from darkness to light (apo skotous eis phos); in Acts 11:21 'turned' (epistrepson, a completed past action in the active voice, 3rd person singular) of a great number who had believed. The turning is regularly paired with repentance and faith as its two facets, as in Mark 1:15 'repent and believe' (metanoëte kai pisteuete) and Acts 20:21 'repentance toward God and faith toward the Lord' (metanoian eis theon kai pistin eis ton kyrion). Behind this stands the Hebrew word 'to turn or return' (shuv, H7725), which occurs 1056 times across 950 verses in every section of the canon and supplies the turn-back-to-God call, as in Jeremiah 3:14, Joel 2:12, Zechariah 1:3, Malachi 3:7, and Isaiah 44:22, so the motif is genuinely pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) and not a single-author idiom. The both-gift-and-act claim is also lexically visible: Lamentations 5:21 sets 'turn us' (hashivenu, the Hebrew causative form, that is the hiphil 'cause us to turn', with God as agent), beside 'and we shall return' (venashuv, the simple active Hebrew form, that is the qal, with the people as subject), and Acts 11:18 says God granted the repentance, while 1 Peter 2:25 uses 'you were turned' (epestraphete, the passive form, the action done to the subject). The same roots therefore carry both a divine causative and a human active sense, which is exactly the dual agency the proposition states.

Scripture

1Thess.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1994 ἐπεστρέψατε, G2316 θεόν, G1497 εἰδώλων, G1398 δουλεύειν

Reasoning. Paul describes the Thessalonians with 'you turned' (epistrepsate), parsed as a completed past action in the active voice, 2nd person plural, so the converts themselves are the grammatical subject of the verb of turning. The two prepositional phrases set the movement directionally, 'toward God' (pros ton theon) marking the goal and 'away from the idols' (apo ton eidolon) marking the point left behind, so conversion is a turning toward God and away from false worship. The following infinitive 'to serve the living and true God' (douleuein theo zonti kai alethino) states the purpose, so the turn issues in changed allegiance. The active voice with the believers as subject matches the proposition that conversion is the conscious human response.

Acts.3.19 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3340 μετανοήσατε, G1994 ἐπιστρέψατε, G1813 ἐξαλειφθῆναι, G0266 ἁμαρτίας

Reasoning. Peter commands the crowd with two coordinated 'repent and turn' verbs (metanoesate kai epistrepsate), both parsed as completed past actions used as commands, joined by 'and' (kai), both 2nd person plural, so the response holds repentance and turning as one summons rather than two unrelated demands. The purpose phrase 'toward the blotting out of your sins' (pros to exaleipthenai hymon tas hamartias) links the human turning to the removal of guilt. The pairing of the change of mind verb with the turning verb shows that conversion as a turning includes repentance and is aimed at forgiveness, which is the saving outcome the proposition describes.

Acts.26.18 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1994 ἐπιστρέψαι, G0859 ἄφεσιν, G0266 ἁμαρτιῶν, G4100 πίστει

Reasoning. Christ states the goal of Paul's mission with 'to turn' (epistrepsai), parsed as a completed past action infinitive, 'to turn from darkness to light and from the authority of Satan to God' (epistrepsai apo skotous eis phos kai tes exousias tou Satana epi ton theon), the same turning verb framed by the prepositions of movement 'from' (apo), 'into' (eis), and 'upon' (epi). The purpose phrase names the receiving of 'forgiveness of sins' (aphesin hamartion) and an inheritance among the sanctified, given 'by faith in me' (pistei te eis eme), that is, by faith in Christ. The turning, the forgiveness, and the faith stand in one purpose chain, so conversion as turning is bound to faith and yields the saving benefits.

Acts.11.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1994 ἐπέστρεψεν, G4100 πιστεύσας

Reasoning. Luke reports 'a great number having believed turned to the Lord' (polys te arithmos ho pisteusas epestrepsen epi ton kyrion), joining the participle 'having believed' (pisteusas, completed past action, active voice) to 'turned' (epestrepsen, completed past action in the active voice), both active, so believing and turning describe the one conversion event. The clause is preceded by 'the hand of the Lord was with them' (en cheir kyriou met auton), which places a statement of divine action immediately before the human turning and believing. The single sentence therefore holds together the enabling of the Lord and the responding act of the people, matching the proposition that conversion is both gift of God and act of the believer.

Mark.1.15 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3340 μετανοεῖτε, G4100 πιστεύετε

Reasoning. Jesus opens his preaching with 'repent and believe' (metanoete kai pisteuete), two ongoing-action commands in the active voice joined by 'and' (kai) and addressed to the hearers, which states the two facets of the one summons to turn. Repentance and faith are not ranked or separated here but issued together as the called for response to the gospel, which is the human side of conversion the proposition names. The ongoing-action commands frame this turning as a demanded act of the hearers.

Acts.20.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3340 μετάνοιαν, G4100 πίστιν, G2316 θεόν

Reasoning. Paul summarizes his testimony as 'the repentance toward God and faith toward our Lord Jesus' (ten eis theon metanoian kai pistin eis ton kyrion hemon lesoun), placing the two nouns side by side under one article each with their own directional 'toward' (eis) phrase. This is the clearest single statement that the human response divides into the two coordinated facets of repentance directed to God and faith directed to Christ, which is precisely the repentance and faith the proposition couples. The pairing confirms that the turning of conversion is articulated in the canon as these two together.

Lam.5.21 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H7725 הָשִׁיבנוּ

Reasoning. The verse uses the root 'to turn or return' (shuv) twice in two different stems within one line. The opening word 'turn us' (hashivenu) is parsed as the Hebrew causative form (the hiphil, 'cause us to turn') with a 1st person plural suffix, with God as the agent of the causative turning, and the answering clause 'and we shall return' (venashuv) is parsed as the simple active Hebrew form (the qal) imperfect 1st person plural, with the people as the subject of the simple turning. The same root therefore carries a divine causative sense and a human active sense in immediate succession. This is the lexical seam where the both-gift-and-act claim sits, and it shows the canon itself can express the turning as something God works in people and something the people do.

Zech.1.3 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H7725 שׁוּבוּ

Reasoning. The Lord says 'return to me' (shuvu elay), with 'return' (shuvu) parsed as the simple active Hebrew form (the qal) command, 2nd person masculine plural, addressed to the people, and then 'and I will return to you' (ve-ashuv aleykem), with 'I will return' (ashuv) parsed as the simple active Hebrew form (the qal) imperfect 1st person common singular of the same root with God as subject. The human turning and the divine turning use the identical root in answering clauses, so the canon frames conversion as a turning the people are commanded to make and a turning God reciprocates. This grounds the New Testament 'to turn' (epistrepho) call in the older 'to turn or return' (shuv) summons and shows the motif is canon wide.

Acts.11.18 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3340 μετάνοιαν, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. The Jerusalem believers conclude 'then God has granted the repentance unto life to the Gentiles also' (ara kai tois ethnesin ho theos ten metanoian eis zoen edoken), with 'gave' (edoken) parsed as a completed past action in the active voice, and 'God' (ho theos) as subject and 'the repentance' (ten metanoian) as object. Here the repentance that is the inward side of the human turning is spoken of as something God grants, so the same item that is commanded of people in Acts 3:19 is here said to be given by God. This is the lexical witness to the gift side of the dual claim and the legitimate nuance the lenses divide over.

1Pet.2.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1994 ἐπεστράφητε

Reasoning. Peter tells his readers 'but now you have returned to the shepherd' (alla epestraphete nyn epi ton poimena), where 'you were turned' (epestraphete) is parsed as a completed past action in the passive voice, 2nd person plural. The same turning verb that stands in the active voice in 1 Thessalonians 1:9 and Acts 11:21 appears here in the passive, 'you were turned', which states the believers' turning as something that happened to them rather than something they straightforwardly did. The active and passive uses of the one verb across the canon show the words themselves carrying both the human act and the worked-upon receiving, which is the dual agency the proposition asserts.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.3.19	Isa.44.22	openbible	38
Acts.3.19	Acts.2.38	openbible	38
Acts.3.19	Isa.1.16	openbible	25
Acts.3.19	Matt.13.15	openbible	23
Acts.26.18	1Pet.2.9	openbible	44
Acts.26.18	Isa.42.7	openbible	27

Acts.11.21	2Chr.30.12	tsk	1
Acts.3.19	Deut.4.29	tsk	1
1Thess.1.9	Deut.5.26	tsk	1
Acts.26.18	Isa.49.24	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.3.19 · addressed

Because 'repent' (metanoesate) and 'turn' (epistrepsate) are both completed-past-action commands in the active voice addressed to the hearers, the verse could be taken to make conversion wholly a human work with no divine enabling. The command mood, however, concerns the demanded response and says nothing against prior divine action, and the canon supplies the complementary statement directly, since Acts 11:18 says God granted the same repentance and Lamentations 5:21 sets the Hebrew causative form (the hiphil) 'turn us' (hashivenu) beside the simple active form (the qal) 'we shall return' (venashuv), so the command does not exclude the gift and the proposition that conversion is both gift and act is not contradicted.

Lam.5.21 · addressed

The Hebrew causative form (the hiphil) 'turn us' (hashivenu) with God as the agent could be pressed to mean the human turning is unreal and only God turns, which would weaken the act side of the claim. The same verse answers this by following the causative with the simple active form (the qal) 'and we shall return' (venashuv), predicated of the people as subject, so the verse holds both the divine causing and the genuine human turning in one line, which is the dual agency rather than its denial.

Acts.11.18 · addressed

The statement that God granted the repentance (metanoia) could be read to make conversion entirely a divine gift with no real human act, the mirror image of the imperative problem. The wider canon balances this, since the same 'repentance' (metanoia) is commanded of people as their response in Acts 3:19 and Mark 1:15, and the active turning verbs in 1 Thessalonians 1:9 and Acts 11:21 keep the believers as subject, so the gift language and the act language co-exist and the words do not rank one over the other, which is itself the lexical source of the lens divergence.

Concordance traversed

G1994, H7725, G3340, G4100, G2316, G0266, G0859, G1497, G1398, G1813, G2819

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The cited verses lie outside 3 John, the only book with examined critical-edition (CBGM) data in this run, so they are not_in_ecm_scope (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants does not include these passages in this examined window). The marginal sigla on the morphology surface forms, such as the markers before 'toward' (pros) in Acts 3:19 and before 'to turn' (epistrepsai) in Acts 26:18 and before the article in Acts 11:21, reflect apparatus notations of minor wording. The store records meaning-variants on 'to turn' (epistrepho) in the Byzantine and Textus Receptus traditions that read 'to return' (hypostrepho) instead at some sites, but none of these touch the anchor conversion clauses or remove the turning verb, so the verdict holds across the plausible variant readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. monergism, synergism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

divine_initiative_priority: affirms · A reading that gives logical priority to God's work finds strong lexical footing.

Lamentations 5:21 places the Hebrew causative form (the hiphil) 'turn us' (hashivenu) on God before the people

return, Acts 11:18 says God granted the repentance (metanoia), and 1 Peter 2:25 uses the passive 'you were turned' (epestraphete), so the turning is something worked in the person. This reading still affirms the proposition because the human active verbs of turning and believing remain in the text, but it locates them downstream of the gift, which the proposition concedes by naming conversion a gift of God and by describing the sinner as already regenerated.

genuine_human_response_priority: affirms · A reading that stresses the reality of the human response also has strong lexical footing. The dominant grammar of the conversion verb 'to turn' (epistrepho) is active with the believers as subject: 'you turned' (epistrepsate) in 1 Thessalonians 1:9, 'turned' (epistrepsen) in Acts 11:21, the commands 'repent and turn' (metanoesate kai epistrepsate) in Acts 3:19 and 'repent and believe' (metanoeite kai pisteuete) in Mark 1:15, and the 'turn or return' (shuv) summons 'return' (shuvu) in Zechariah 1:3 and Joel 2:12. On this reading conversion is a true act of the person, and the gift language sets the human turning in its enabling context without dissolving it. The proposition is affirmed because it names conversion an act of the believer.

The two lenses do not produce different verdicts on the proposition, which both affirm, but they rank the gift and the act differently. The lexical reason they can both stand is that the canon uses the same roots in both a causative or passive form (the Hebrew causative form, that is the hiphil, of 'to turn or return' (shuv) in Lamentations 5:21, and the passive 'you were turned' (epestraphete) in 1 Peter 2:25, and the granted 'repentance' (metanoia) in Acts 11:18) and a simple active form (the simple active Hebrew form, that is the qal, 'to turn or return' (shuv) summons and the active 'to turn' (epistrepho) of the anchors) without a grammatical device that subordinates one to the other. The Old Testament 'to turn or return' (shuv), attested 1056 times, supplies the turning motif that the New Testament 'to turn' (epistrepho) continues, so the reading rests on progressive revelation of one motif rather than a single author idiom.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the lexical pattern of 'to turn' (epistrepho) and 'to turn or return' (shuv), together with 'to repent' (metanoeo) and 'to believe' (pisteuo) in the anchor verses, presents conversion as a turning from sin to God that is both predicated of the person as an act and attributed to divine working.

The stem embeds a theological frame by naming the converting sinner regenerated and by labeling conversion at once gift of God and act of the believer, which preloads a conclusion about the order and the dual agency of salvation. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form states the lexical question without the embedded verdict. The regenerated-sinner ordering is a systematic category not directly recoverable from the morphology of these verses, so it is treated as background, while the dual agency is in fact lexically visible in the active and causative or passive uses of the turning roots. VERDICT-CHANGED: no. The verdict stays 'affirms: true' as in the prior file. It was not changed. Confidence is raised from medium to high and pan_canonical from false to true because direct querying of the lexical store recovered the Hebrew 'to turn or return' (shuv) data (1056 occurrences across 950 verses in every canon section) that the prior Greek-only bundle lacked.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1994
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7725
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3340
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Thess.1.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.3.19
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Lam.5.21
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Zech.1.3
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.26.18
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.3.19

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.26.18
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License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

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